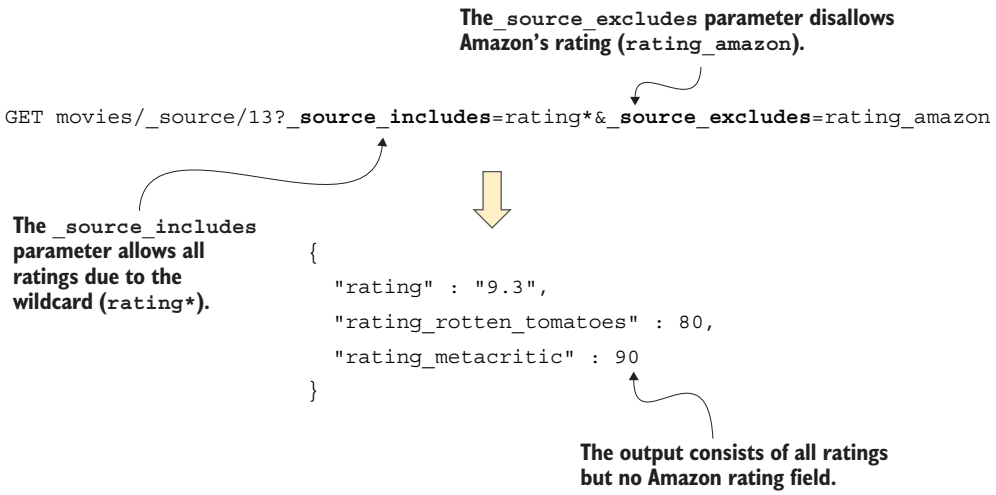


Figure 5.11 Tweaking what attributes are and are not part of the return result

So far, we've seen how to create and read documents, including manipulating responses. We now understand the mechanics of updating the documents. There will always be a need to update existing documents by modifying an existing field's value or adding a new field. Elasticsearch provides a set of update APIs for this purpose, discussed in the next section.

5.4 Updating documents

Indexed documents sometimes need to be updated with modified values or additional fields, or the entire document may need to be replaced. Similar to indexing documents, Elasticsearch provides two types of update queries—one for working against single documents and the other for working on multiple documents:

- The `_update` API updates a single document.
- `_update_by_query` allows us to modify multiple documents at the same time.

Before we look at some examples, we need to understand the mechanics involved when updating documents. Let's do that next.

5.4.1 Document update mechanics

Elasticsearch requires a few steps when we update documents. Figure 5.12 illustrates the procedure: Elasticsearch first fetches the document, modifies it, and then reindexes it. Essentially, it *replaces* the old document with a new document. Behind the scenes, Elasticsearch creates a new document for updates. During this update, Elasticsearch increments the version of the document once the update operation completes. When the newer version of the document (with the modified values or new fields) is ready, it marks the older version for deletion.